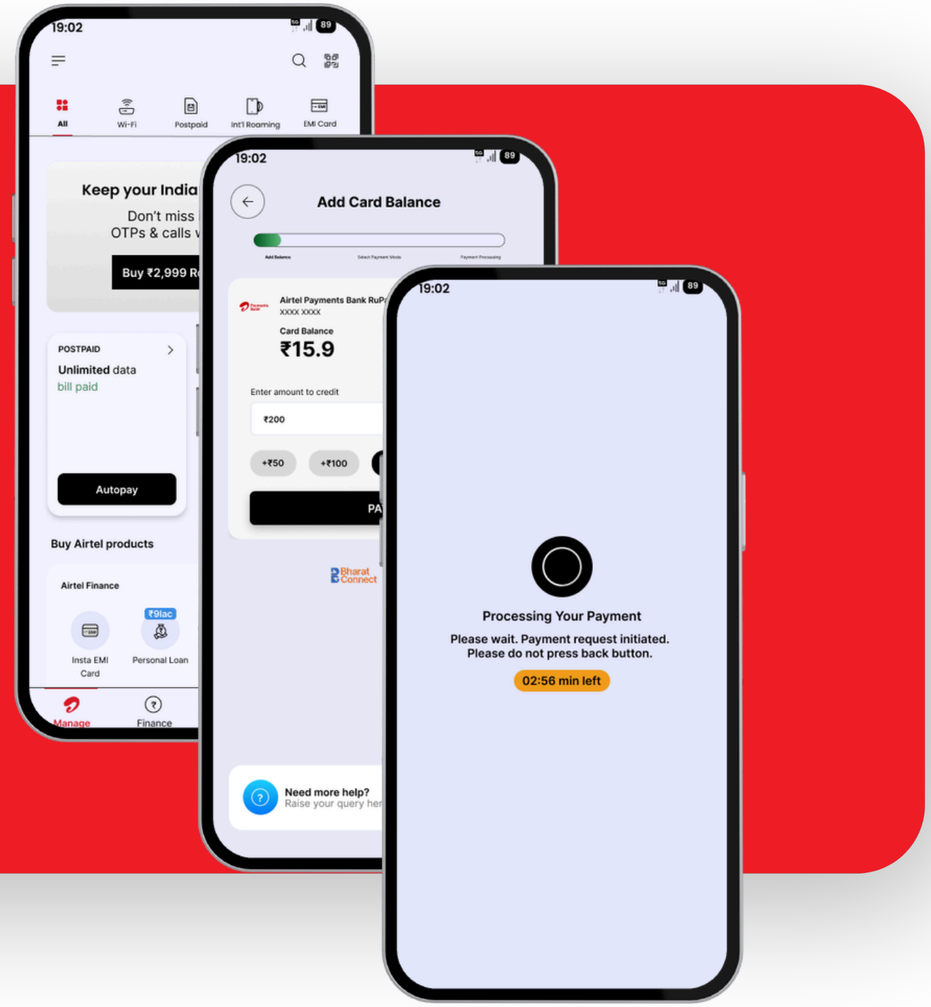
PRODUCT MANAGEMENT | UX CASE STUDY

Airtel Thanks App

Redesigning the Airtel Payments Bank RuPay NCMC Recharge Journey



LAAVANYA NEGI
Product Management Case Study

CONTEXT

A daily-use card. A time-sensitive task.

The case study focuses on recharging registered Airtel Payments Bank RuPay NCMC cards in the Airtel Thanks app.

PRODUCT CONTEXT

Everyday commuting

Users top up their NCMC cards for transport and other eligible payments.

Two discovery routes

Recharge starts from the homepage action or through search.

Business relevance

A smoother recharge experience to support completion and reduce avoidable app abandonment.

PRODUCT OBJECTIVE

To make NCMC recharge easier to find, faster to navigate, and clearer while payment is processing.

Research identified friction at three moments

Extracted from user observations, interviews, public app reviews and competitor review.

08 **Observed participants**
Existing recharge journeys

03 **Interviews**
Participants aged 18–55

03 **Review platforms**
Reddit · X · Google Play

RESEARCH FINDINGS

01 Discovery	Recharge action not quickly identified on the homepage.
02 Navigation	Repeated screens, slow loading and information overload.
03 Feedback	Unclear payment progress; reviews also reported balance discrepancies.

3 User Personas. 1 recurring journey problem.

Prioritised **Rohan** for time-sensitive frequent recharges while incorporating shared needs of Anitha and Ramesh.

R

ROHAN · 20

College day scholar

Quick ₹50–₹100 top-ups near metro turnstiles.

Needs speed; struggles with too many screens and connectivity.

A

ANITHA · 44

Working single mother

Manages her own and her son’s transit card recharges.

Needs reassurance during larger payments and clear transaction status.

R

RAMESH · 66

Retired government employee

Occasional metro travel to visit relatives.

Needs readable controls and confidence against payment mistakes.

PRIORITY PERSONA: ROHAN

PROBLEM

The recharge journey asked too much of users

Observed and reported friction was concentrated in discovery, navigation, and payment reassurance.

01

Button hard to locate

Recharge entry point lacks sufficient prominence.

02

Too many screens

Additional navigation compounds waiting and cognitive effort.

03

Uncertain payment

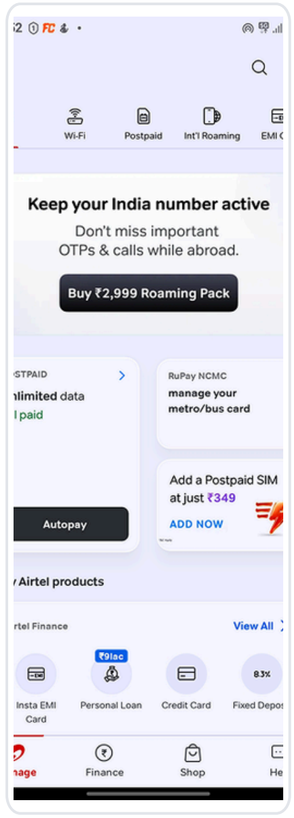
Lack of visible stage/status weakens confidence.

OBJECTIVE

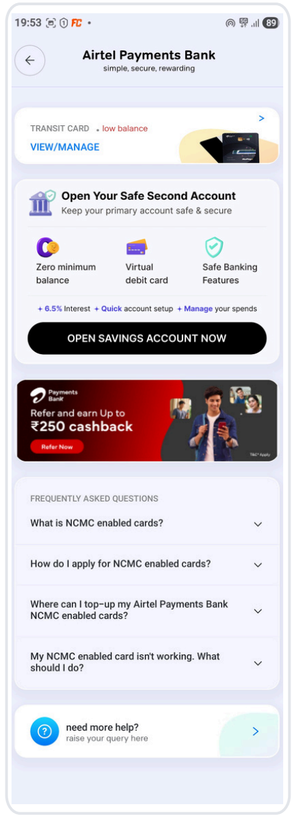
To help commuters recharge their registered NCMC card with fewer decisions and reliable progress visibility.

User Journey: Homepage-button flow

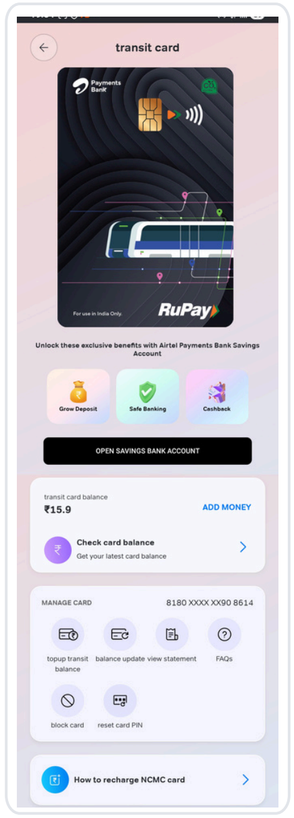
Selected source screens show the principal stages; alternate processing and failed-payment states are documented in the archive.



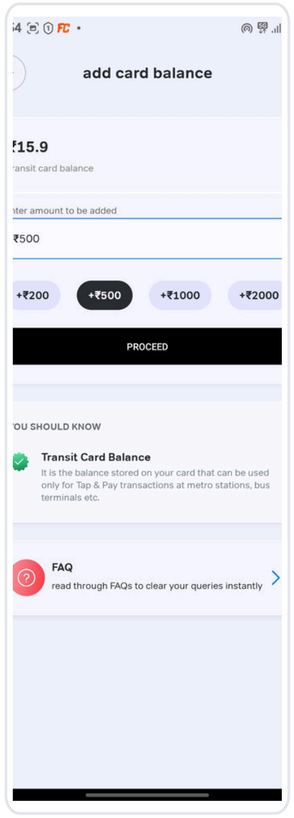
01 Homepage



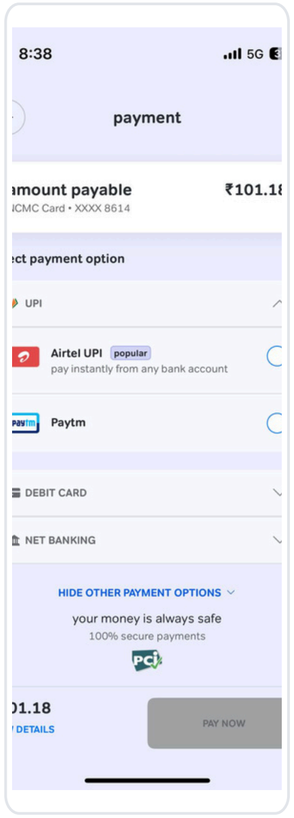
02 Icon selection



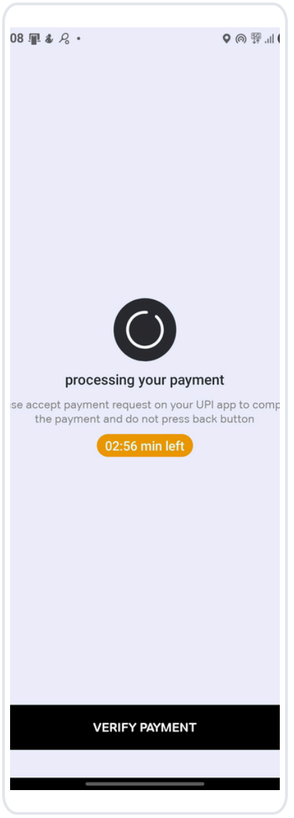
03 Card selection



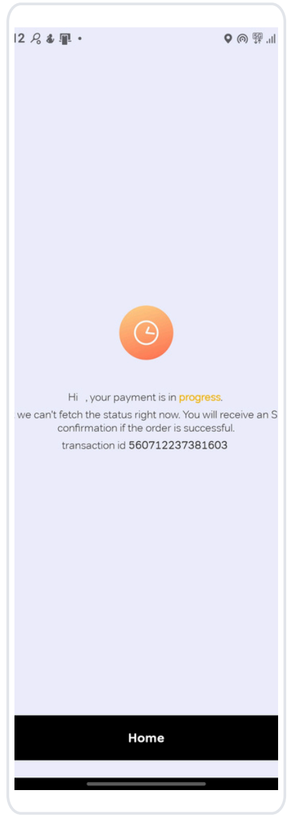
04 Add money



05 Payment mode



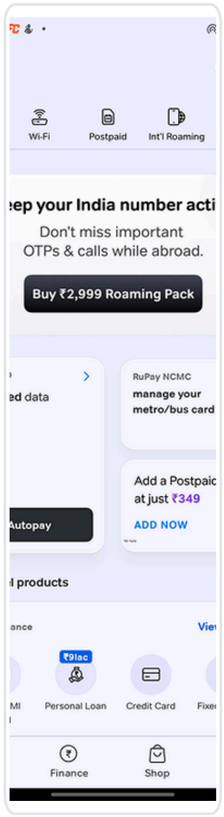
06 Payment Processing



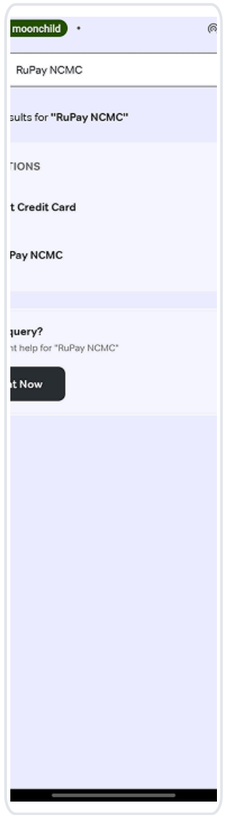
07 Processing Screen

User Journey: Search icon flow

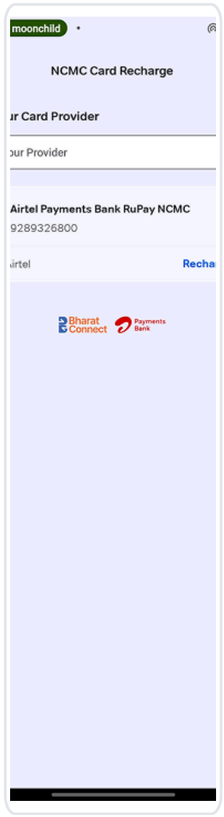
The user begins in search and proceeds to card/payment actions before reaching transaction processing.



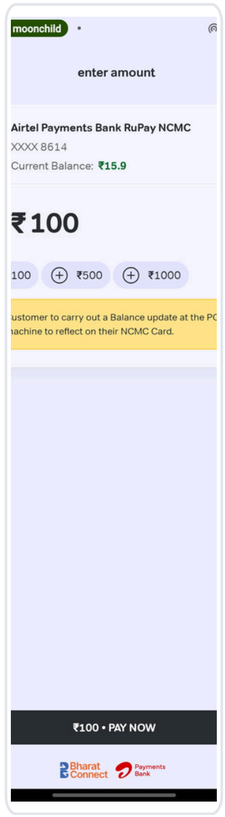
01 Homepage



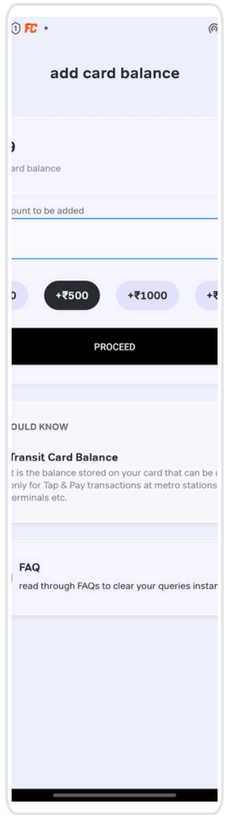
02 Search action



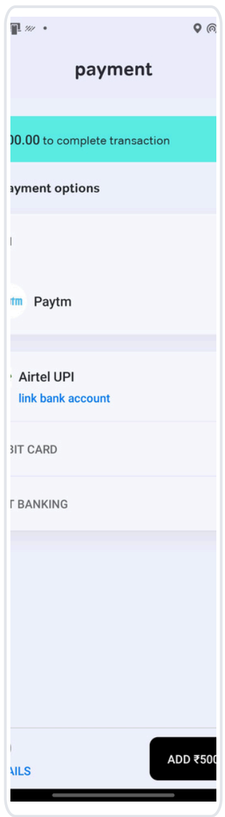
03 Search results



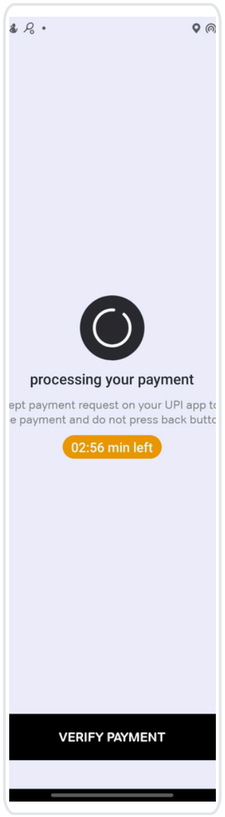
04 Card/status



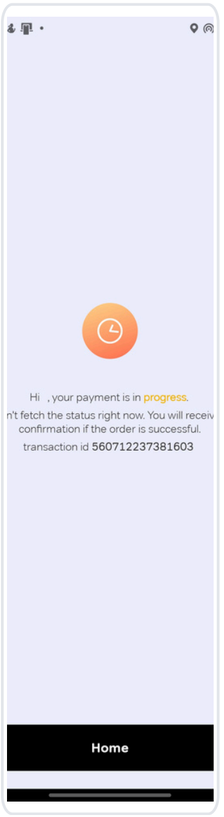
05 Add money



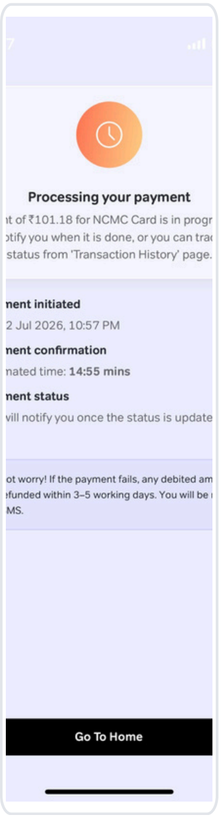
06 Payment option



07 Payment processing



08 Processing screen



09 Final screen

PRIORITISATION

Prioritise shared friction before adding complexity

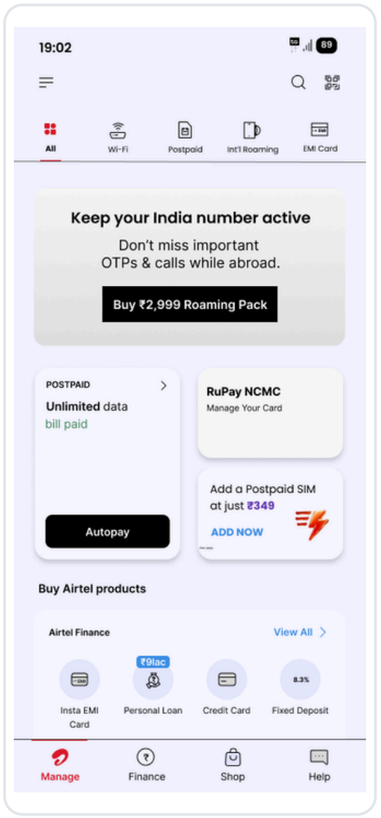
MoSCoW prioritisation method used from the product teardown, with implementation status separated from priority.

MUST	**Improve homepage recharge discovery**	Designed
MUST	**Reduce unnecessary recharge screens**	Designed
SHOULD	**Add payment progress visibility**	Designed
SHOULD	**₹50 micro-recharge quick selection**	Designed
COULD	Post-recharge NFC top-up prompt	Future consideration
WON'T	Automatic payment triggers	Future consideration

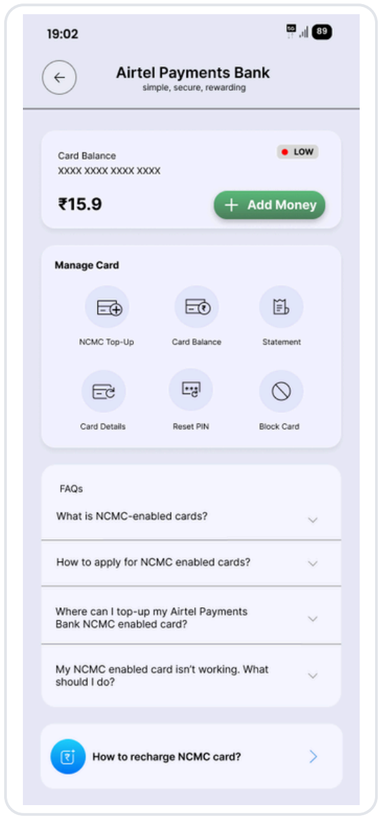
The three central changes address all personas; ₹50 quick selection additionally supports smaller, time-sensitive top-ups.

Redesgined Prototype: Homepage-button flow

Actual high-fidelity prototype screens. The ₹50 quick-select action appears on the add-balance screen.



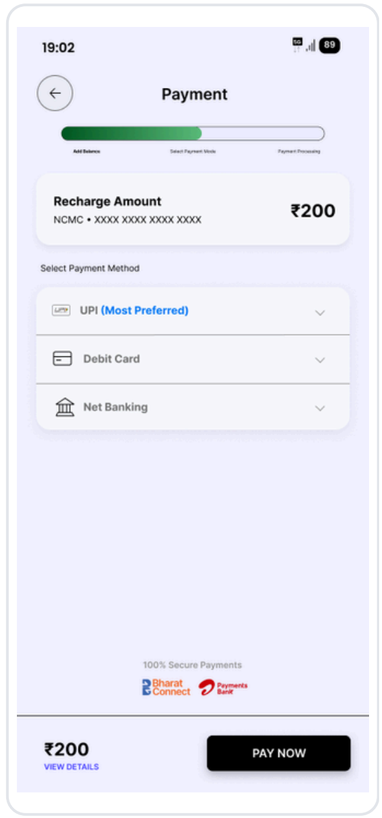
01 Homepage



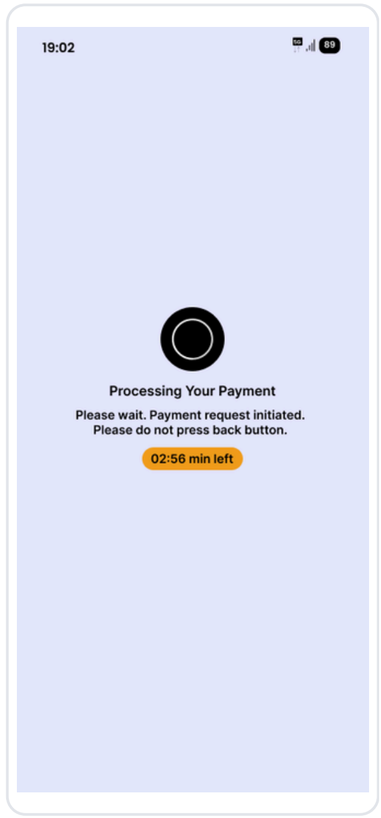
02 Card selection



03 Add balance · +₹50



04 Payment

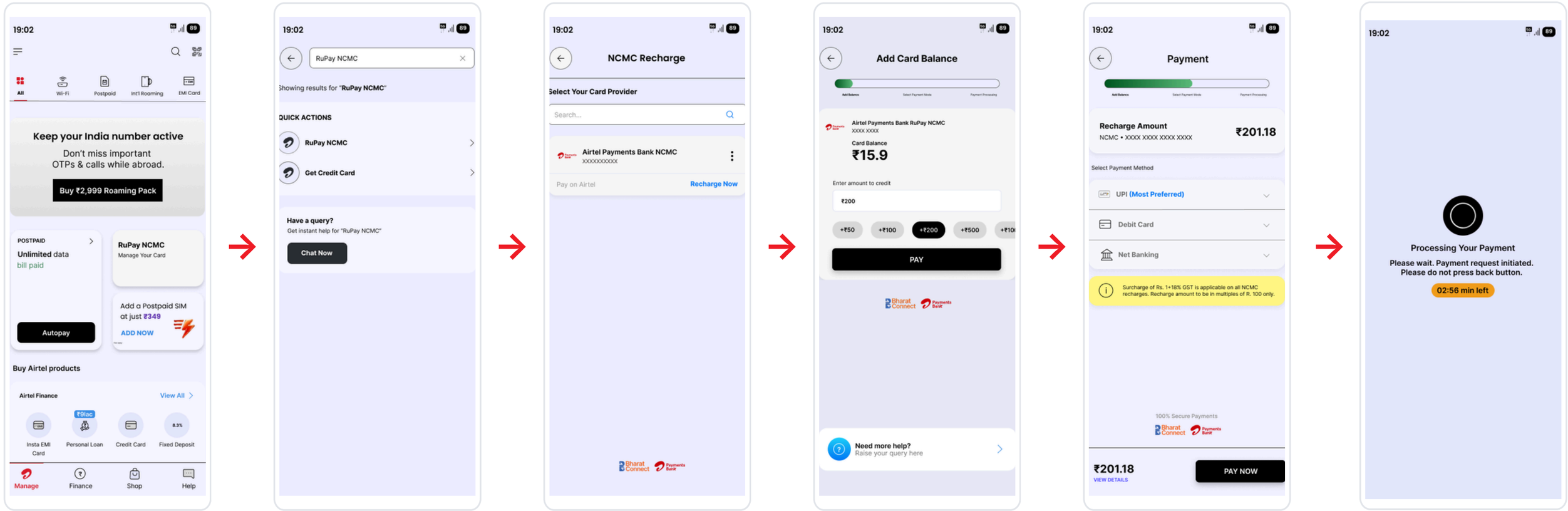


05 Processing

Prototype also includes successful and unsuccessful outcome screens, discussed in the payment feedback comparison.

Redesigned Prototype: Search icon flow

Search screens take users into the same simplified recharge and processing experience.



01 Homepage → **02 Search** → **03 Search result** → **04 Add balance** → **05 Payment** → **06 Processing**

The redesigned flow then provides processing, success and failure feedback states.

Four targeted changes, common pain point to all users

A product decision should be traceable from a user need to the concrete interface change.

01 Make recharge visible

Increase emphasis on the homepage recharge action.

DISCOVERABILITY

02 Shorten the path

Consolidate selections across recharge and payment steps.

NAVIGATION

03 Show transaction status

Display progress through processing and outcome stages.

CONFIDENCE

04 Offer +₹50 selection

Add a low-value quick selection for short-trip commuters.

CONVENIENCE

MEASUREMENT

Guerrilla Usability Testing, followed by Product outcomes

Only task-time and qualitative observations were measured in the provided guerrilla test.

TESTED

Mean end-to-end task completion time

Original app vs high-fidelity prototype

PROPOSED

Successful recharge completion rate

Funnel numerator / initiated recharge attempts

PROPOSED

Drop-off by stage

Home/search → card → amount → payment → outcome

GUARDRAILS

Payment errors, card sync, tap latency

Monitor alongside any released flow change

Proposed production experiment: compare a controlled rollout against the existing journey, monitor completion and drop-off, and stop or iterate if payment reliability worsens.

49.81% less time to complete a recharge

Eight participants completed the same task in the original app and the redesigned prototype; timing ended at the confirmation screen.

MEAN TRANSACTION COMPLETION TIME



133 seconds saved per transaction on average



03 students

04 working mothers

03 senior citizens

49.81%

reduction in mean completion time

Qualitative observation: less hesitation locating recharge, easier navigation, and reduced payment uncertainty.

PM Takeaways

What this independent product case study demonstrates, and what would come next.

Prioritise the shared pain

Fix the highest-friction moments before expanding feature scope.

Make status visible

During payments, confidence depends on timely, understandable feedback.

Validate with real tasks

Eight paired tests provided early usability evidence, not production business impact.

NEXT STEPS

Instrument recharge funnels → run a controlled rollout → monitor payment, card-sync and tap reliability.